

Married to Controversy



STIRRING A STORM:
Naish (left), Hameed
and Naeem

MANEESH AGNIHOTRI

A social activist of Lucknow sets a new trend by getting her own nikah solemnised by a woman qazi

■ By Farzand Ahmed

Naish Hasan, 30, has always been seen as an iconoclast, a champion of Muslim women's causes and a crusader against the dominance of clerics who seldom practised what they preached about equality in Islam. Last week, the founder-president of the Bharatiya Muslim Mahila Andolan went a step forward: she got her nikah with friend Imran Naeem of Delhi solemnised by Syeda Saiyyadain Hameed, well-known Islamic scholar and member of the Planning Commission who played the role of a qazi (clergy). The event exploded like a bombshell in the Muslim society. Across the Islamic world, the role of the qazi has been reserved strictly for males. "This is an attempt to initiate change and a break away from tradition. We are trying to implement the change on ourselves," said Naish.

What makes the issue even more meaningful is that the act has not been

done by obscure and illiterate publicity seekers. Naish is a postgraduate in economics while Naeem is a Ph.D from the Aligarh Muslim University. She runs a social organisation with units spread over 15 states while he runs an NGO in Delhi. Hameed, on the other hand, is the founder-member of the Muslim Women's Forum that has been involved in "legal literacy for Muslim women", for voicing the concerns of Muslim women to the Government and interfacing with ulemas.

Naturally, their attempt to break with tradition and tamper with Islamic order has created a turmoil in the Muslim world in which the settled principle is that only a male Muslim can lead prayers (the only exception is if an all-woman congregation prays in a separate mosque, a female Muslim can lead it) and women cannot conduct nikah. The tradition is based on the belief that the prayer of a woman is detestable if she has offered it while standing among males in a mosque.